

Program Plan: Gifted Children

Megan Jordan

MLIS 4015: User and Access Services

Katy Walker

May 28th, 2024

Outlined herein is a school library program plan for the user group of upper elementary gifted students. This user group shares many qualities with typical children of the same age, but also has some specific differences. Gifted students are fast thinkers and can absorb a lot of information in a short time (Gifted Traits and Characteristics). However, they can get overwhelmed by a lot of options and therefore may freeze or be unable to differentiate when given a lot of results (Post, 2017). They have a higher level of comprehension than their peers, but their maturity level may not match that ability, so reader advisory is very important for them to find engaging reading material (Churchill, 2020, p. 26).

A needs assessment for this user group will involve an overview of the district gifted program requirements, interviewing the school gifted program coordinator or expert and observing gifted students in their classroom. Ordinary programming typically does not stimulate gifted students (Ali, 2018). “Programs directed to gifted lead to increase in their ability” (Ali, 2018). In addition, this program is an excellent way for young students to start to learn about how to work as a team and how to rely, and be relied upon, as a team member (Scullen, 2020). These traits and needs are all considered when designing this program plan.

Considering the specific traits of this user group, a great library program is Battle of the Books. This program is a trivia game that promotes voluntary reading, which in turn can promote “self-directed lifelong learning (Garces & Yep, 2017, p. 260). Battle of the Books utilizes many of their special skills – absorbing a lot of information, high level of comprehension and fast thinking. Their reading list is limited so they will not get overwhelmed by too many book options. These traits are funneled into a fun competition.

This particular program will use Family Feud style battle, which is common and recommended for this age group (Six Styles of Competition).

Elementary school librarians will plan with the gifted students' schoolteacher or English teacher in advance and use regularly scheduled library class to implement this program. Co-Teaching this program with the English teacher will pay off in multiple ways. There is a strong correlation between academic achievement and teacher-librarian collaboration (Koh et al., 2022). Planning in advance will synergize the learning objectives of both the librarian and teacher. In addition, the students will have additional motivation to complete all of their required reading and incentive to read more voluntarily.

The reading list for this battle will contain twelve books. In advance of the program, the librarian and teacher will consider books that are part of the English curriculum as well as general Readers Advisory for this age group. Differentiated book choices are important for this user group to increase reading comprehension and interest (Shaunessey-Dedrick et al., 2015, P. 92). It is also important to consider diverse books for this user group (Roberson, 2023, p. 10). The reading list will be comprised of six books will be from the teacher's curriculum and six will be chosen from the librarians' Readers Advisory. School librarians should make sure the books on the list are stocked in their library. In addition, notifying the public library of this program, and that that they may have an influx of requests for books on the book list will ensure they are prepared as well.

Next, the teacher and librarian will create the list of questions for the battle. The list should have a minimum of 60 questions and have a variety of question types such as

multiple choice, fill in the blank, and open ended questions. The teacher and librarian can work together to create questions whose answers will illustrate understanding of the curriculum objectives as well as reading comprehension and literacy. Working together in this way with co-teaching elevates the program and its impact on the students.

The class size will be 24-30 students, broken into teams of three to four students. It is necessary for there to be an even number of teams. For the purposes of this plan, there will be eight teams. Each team will be assigned the previously decided upon book list. The books will be split between members of the team, so that each student is responsible for reading 20-25% of the list. Of course, any student is welcome and encouraged to read the entire book list. A compelling book list, and a good-natured competitive spirit, is meant to incentive voluntary reading beyond each students minimum portion of reading.

Starting in January at a regular weekly library class, the librarian can create the teams, hand out the book list and explain the terms of the Battle. The specific timing will be decided in conjunction with the English teacher, but generally the students will be given two to three months to complete all of their reading. During subsequent library sessions, teams can be given time to come up with names, mascots and check in on their reading.

The Battle part of the program will then begin in March or April and last for three weeks, or three library classes. It is set up as a tournament. A posterboard tournament bracket hung in the library, updated after each battle, is a fun way to keep the kids excited and invested in the outcome. The staff required will be four adults, or hosts, for the

duration of the three classes. The librarian and teacher will be two hosts. Two additional hosts will need to be secured in advance and can be available staff or volunteer teachers.

Each of the eight teams will be paired with another team for their first Battle, creating four pairs of two teams. These teams represent the first sets of battles; four battles will be happening concurrently. Each pair of teams is set up at two tables which face each other, the students from each team next to each other and facing their opposing team. If the library is not big enough to accommodate this, it may be necessary to contact school administration in advance to use the cafeteria or auditorium. Each host will need a stopwatch, the previously written list of questions and a pen and pad for keeping score.

Once the teams are in place and ready to start, the adult supervisor will begin asking questions. Each team is able to put their heads together to decide how best to answer. The team that raises their hand first, and answers the question correctly, receives a point. This goes on until the host has asked 20 of the 60 questions. The points are tallied and totaled at the end of each battle. Each question is timed and if neither team can answer in 30 seconds, no team is awarded points. This Battle will take the entirety of this library class session.

At the next class, the same set up is needed. The top winners of prior Battles will play against the winners of the other two battles. Alternatively, the rest of the teams that did not win will also Battle each other. The next 20 questions should be ready for this session. At the end of this class, points are added to their previous total. The tournament bracket will be updated at the end of the session to place each team in their correct standing.

In the last week of the Battle, the top two teams Battle each other for first place. The rest of the teams are matched again and play for their placement in the Battle. The last 20 questions will be asked during this session. These questions can be some of the more open-ended questions and may be allotted more time to answer (up to 60 seconds). Asking more detailed or thought-provoking questions in the final round will hone in on the comprehension and memory of the students.

At the end of this final Battle the points are totaled, and the winner is announced. Ideally the librarian is able to secure a prize, but even if not, a trophy or ribbon is still a fun reward for students. The winner is just for fun; all students will have read more books than they would have otherwise and compete with the same questions. This concludes Battle of the Books programming event.

There is not much outreach needed for this programming. It is meant for students already attending a library class at school. If this were an extracurricular activity at a school, it would definitely need outreach to let students know it exists and encourage participation.

There are a few important ways to assess this program. One is to look at the results of the Battles. As the adults are asking questions and assigning points, they should also take notes on which questions were answered incorrectly and if any questions were not able to be answered. If there were a number of questions that no teams could answer correctly in any of the Battles, it's important for the librarian and teacher to look at any trends in where students missed points. This quantitative data will lend insight into if the students didn't read certain books or didn't properly comprehend them. It will help assess

if some books were too hard for their reading level or the students need more discussion to understand them.

Another way to assess the impact is to ask the class what they thought of the program. After the last Battle, have an open discussion about what students did and didn't like, what they thought was hard or easy, and what excited them or didn't. This will give a broad picture of how the program impacted the students as a whole. In addition, ask the students to write a brief reflection paper on how the Battles did or did not impact their interest in the books and their understanding of them. This qualitative data will help shape better programming in the future.

One way this programming could fail is if many students aren't reading the books or aren't retaining the story and information from the books. This could happen for several reasons. One reason is that they weren't given enough time to read their portion of the list. Another reason is that the book list doesn't have books of interest to the user group. This would lead to many missed questions during each battle, and a less interesting and less engaging competition. More importantly, the students would not be completing their learning objectives, increasing their voluntary readership or reading comprehension and literacy.

Battle of the Books is a program that has been successful all over the country but not catered to any user group. This program targets the traits of this specific user group to elevate the program to their needs. Overall, it will be a fun, engaging and enjoyable experience for the students and adults.

References

- Ali, Dr. M. E. A. (2018). School and Public Libraries and its Role in Supporting Gifted Students: Field Study. *Life Science Journal*, 15(10). Retrieved from http://www.lifesciencesite.com/ljsj/life151018/12_34153ljsj151018_101_111.pdf
- Churchill, S. (2020). Left to chance: gifted students & independent reading. *Knowledge Quest*, 48(5), 24-31. Retrieved from <https://du.idm.oclc.org/login?url=https://www.proquest.com/scholarly-journals/left-chance-gifted-students-amp-independent/docview/2393073839/se-2>
- Garces-Bacsal, R., & Yeo, S. D. (2017). Why and what they read when they don't have to: Factors influencing the recreational reading habits of gifted students in Singapore. *Journal for the Education of the Gifted*, 40(3), 247-265. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0162353217717035>
- Gifted Traits and Characteristics. (n.d.). *Davidson Institute*. <https://www.davidsongifted.org/prospective-families/gifted-traits-and-characteristics/>
- Koh, K., Ge, X., Petrella, & (), J. B. (2022). Librarian-teacher co-teaching and the role of school librarians in facilitating inquiry and maker learning. *School Library Research*, 25. Retrieved from <https://du.idm.oclc.org/login?url=https://www.proquest.com/scholarly-journals/librarian-teacher-co-teaching-role-school/docview/2833945652/se-2>
- Post, Gail. (2017, May 1). *Gifted Overthinkers: what makes them tick?* Gifted Challenges. <https://giftedchallenges.blogspot.com/2017/05/gifted-overthinkers-what-makes-them-tick.html>
- Scullen, Julie. (2020, February 21). *Battle of the Books: How 25 Books Can Help Shape Students*. International Literacy Association. <https://www.literacyworldwide.org/blog/literacy-now/2020/02/21/battle-of-the-books>
- Six Styles of Competition. (n.d.). *Battle of the Books*. Retrieved May 20, 2024 from <https://www.battleofthebooks.org/six-styles-of-competition/>
- Roberson, J. J. (2023). The battle of book selection for gifted students. *Teaching for High Potential*, 10-11. Retrieved from <https://du.idm.oclc.org/login?url=https://www.proquest.com/scholarly-journals/battle-book-selection-gifted-students/docview/2897291544/se-2>
- Shaunessy-Dedrick, E., Evans, L., Ferron, J., & Lindo, M. (2015). Effects of differentiated reading on elementary students' reading comprehension and attitudes toward reading. *Gifted Child Quarterly*, 59(2), 91-107. <https://doi.org/du.idm.oclc.org/10.1177/0016986214568718>

Appendix A

Hand out for Students

GOT BOOKS?

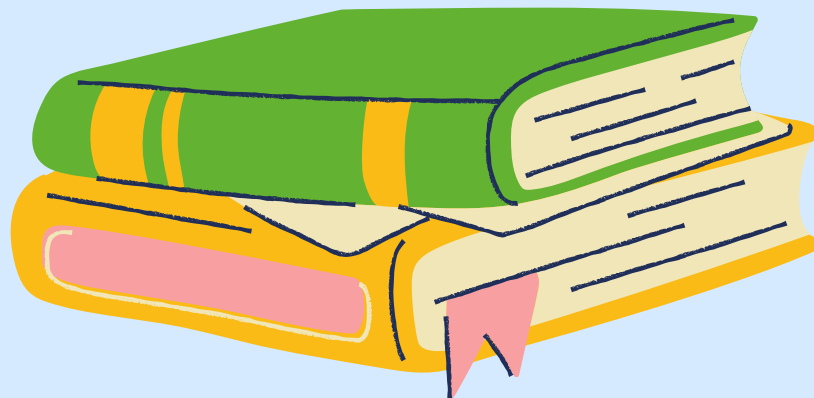
Battle of the Books

5th Graders - Get Ready to Battle!

Battle of the Books starts this January!

Read the Books
Answer the questions
Claim your victory

During regular library class, battle your knowledge of books with your classmates and find out who is the ultimate victor!



Appendix B

Handout for colleagues

Why Battle of the Books is so effective for gifted 5th graders



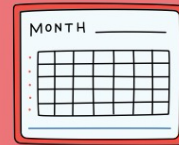
Gifted students have special abilities

Gifted students can retain a lot of information in a short time, and can comprehend at a higher level than their peers.



Goals of the Battle

The Battle is meant to incentivize reading and create a fun activity to energize their reading.



Co-Teaching is key

Co-Teaching with an English teacher can synergize goals - adding higher achievement and value to what's already in the curriculum.



Plan your Activities

Plan ahead with the subject teacher and the school staff to make a seamless programming event.

Contact

Megan Jordan
Burbank Elementary School Librarian
24/25 Academic Year
Megan.Jordan@busd.edu
818-731-0496

Appendix C

User Profile

David is a ten-year-old boy in fourth grade at a public elementary school. His family is in a lower socio-economic class. He is an enthusiastic reader, loves LEGOs, science documentaries, and has been identified as a gifted student. He is a fast thinker and can absorb a lot of information in a short time. Unlike other kids his age, he has a higher level of comprehension than his emotional maturity may allow for. He can get overwhelmed with a lot of options and therefore may freeze or be unable to differentiate when given a lot of results.

The biggest barrier to the library for David, first and foremost being a minor, is the ability to get to the library, needing parent or guardian assistance to drive him there and pick him up, as well as help them sign up for a membership card. Another barrier is that he can be overwhelmed by a lot of information and resources and may not yet have been taught how to use the library.

Because of this, he may not know where to start to look for either fun reading or instructional information. Being an avid reader, he has a higher level of reading comprehension than his emotional intelligence is prepared for, so he may have trouble finding books that look interesting or challenging to him. Due to his families socio- economic standing, he is school dependent on finding extra-curricular reading and receiving gifted student services.